The Shadow

By Conrad Bishop and Elizabeth Fuller

INTRODUCTION

MORT: Sickness is weakness.
MARA: There's humiliation and vulnerability in being a patient.
MORT: Treatment can be impersonal
MARA: or incompetent.
MORT: or maybe, impossible.
BOTH: "The Shadow"
MARA: By Conrad Bishop and Elizabeth Fuller

(MORT and MARA in nightclothes, getting into bed, adjusting pillows, bantering but very edgy)

MORT: Beddy-bye.

MARA: When do we have to get up?

MORT: When's your appointment?

MARA: Nine. Then I'll bring the car back and you go for yours.

MORT: Why'd you make our checkups on the same day?

MARA: That way everything's done.

MORT: Suppose we're both sick?

MARA: If you're sick you're sick.

MORT: If I know it I'm sicker.

MARA: You had too much to drink.

MORT: Alcohol sterilizes. My germs are clean.

MARA: They'll look inside you and find pickled gut.

MORT: Put your sick mind to sleep.

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MARA: I feel strange.

MORT: *(Settling in)* Get some sleep, honey.

MARA: *(Settling in)* Don't act like my doctor. *(Pause. Instant shift of worlds: he stands upright, looming over her. She sits, rigid.)*

MORT: Hello, I'm your doctor. How do you feel?

MARA: All right.

MORT: Headaches? Hallucinations?

MARA: No.

MORT: How old are your parents? Epilepsy? Seizures? Searches? When did you have a bath?

MARA: Never.

MORT: What did they tell you in school? Do you like the feel of cotton sheets? Can you take criticism? Dizzy spells? Ringworm? Rats?

MARA: Nothing.

MORT: How'd you like to die?

MARA: Wait! *(Blurred focus: they are suspended between dream and waking.)* I need sleep.

MORT: Go to sleep.

MARA: I feel strange. *(Again they mesh into the nightmare.)*

MORT: Hello, I'm your doctor. How do you feel?

MARA: My watch stopped.

MORT: That's messy. You need a big lead box.

MARA: I need a nap.

MORT: Nap. OK. Procedures and risks involved. First we freeze you, make a small incision, insert a tube up the aorta, watch its progress by fluoroscope.

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Then we inject the dye. You'll feel a burning sensation for fifteen seconds. At this point you sometimes have a reaction, but it can't be proven until you die. Then we x-ray the remains and before you clog we yank out the tubes and try to stop the blood. At this point you often think of tall buildings swaying in the wind. We try to keep you back from the edge, but there is a slight chance, say half of one percent, that you may lose your balance and fall.

MARA: Am I worried?

MORT: Twice a day.

MARA: Risk? Is there any risk?

MORT: There's always some risk. Less on a passbook account, but there you get only five and a half percent. Municipals are still a good buy, but if your inner city deteriorates, you're gonna have problems with flushing.

MARA: What about malignancy?

MORT: It's like inflation. Eats away at what you've got.

MARA: How long am I in for?

MORT: Well, you can put it in five-year certificates, but I'd recommend a shorter confinement unless you want long-term security at the cost of short-term inflammation.

MARA: Wait! We're not talking about money

MORT: *(Grasping her hand voraciously)* I am! I'm a doctor! How do you feel?

MARA: Confused!

MORT: *(Suddenly solicitous)* That's natural. And I'd love to help you. I'd be more than willing to help you. But I'm a doctor. Medicine is not an exact science. Medicine is an art. I'm an artist.

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MARA: It's cold.

MORT: You don't expect all painters to paint rosy pictures. You don't expect all writers to write happy endings.

MARA: Clammy.

MORT: There's comic medicine and there's serious medicine. My medicine makes a statement: *Nobody lives forever!*

MARA: Ahhhhhhh! *(He strangles her. She screams. They wake into reality. lying side by side in bed.)*

MORT: What's the matter?

MARA: I was dreaming. You were the doctor.

MORT: That's a laugh.

MARA: If you're the doctor you're safe. Nothing to lose.

MORT: Relax.

MARA: It's like auto mechanics. You never know.

MORT: Relax and get to sleep.

MARA: Beddy-bye.

MORT: And try not to yell when we start.

MARA: Start what?

MORT: Cutting. *(Nightmare: he grabs her from behind. cuts her throat.)*

MARA: Stop it! Stop! I'm the nurse!

MORT: *(Releasing her)* Oh my God. Sorry. Here, let me button you up.

MARA: It's all right, I'm on the pill. I

MORT: Thank God. Read me the appointments, we're behind schedule.

MARA: There's Mr. Pillsbury.

MORT: Mr. Pillsbury's cancer. I'm sick of his damn cancer. Everybody got a

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cancer. It's his funeral.

MARA: There's Mrs. Pillsbury, for an abortion.

MORT: How advanced is the pregnancy?

MARA: He'll be nineteen this fall.

MORT: Nurse, people have no respect for human life. They don't deserve to live.

MARA: There's *Dr.* Pillsbury

MORT: Dr. Pillsbury? That's not right. I'm Dr. Pillsbury.

MARA: You're on the list.

MORT: But I'm the doctor.

MARA: It's on the list.

MORT: You'll be sorry. I'm the doctor. I'll stand up and shake your hand! *(They clasp hands, shake violently.)*

BOTH: Hello, I'm your doctor, how do you feel? *(Mort sinks down, Mara dominant.)*

MORT: Well... I don't feel any lumps. I really need to get home. My driver's license expires on Friday, I have to study for the test, I have to get my eyes opened. Couldn't I still be the doctor?

MARA: I can't find the vein.

MORT: The grass needs mowing, it's getting too high to cut.

MARA: I can't find the vein.

MORT: It's growing too fast. The doctors are amazed.

MARA: I'm the doctor, I can't find the vein.

MORT: But Friday I'm due to expire!

MARA: Gotcha!

MORT: Ahhhhhhhhh! *(They wake.)*

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MARA: Bad dream?

MORT: Doctors.

MARA: Relax. *(Blurred focus)*

MORT: I should have had it out. In school my friends had everything taken out. I should have done it then.

MARA: Are you the doctor or the patient?

MORT: I forgot.

MARA: It's safer to be the doctor.

MORT: Can he wear a white hat?

MARA: I'll be the doctor, too. Then we're a team.

MORT: A medical team.

MARA: MDs!

MORT: Men in white!

MARA: Doctor!

MORT: Doc! *(They embrace, then recoil.)*

MARA: Oh dear, I contaminated you.

MORT: I was sterile. Wait! The operation! *(Focusing on an imaginary patient)* But there's nobody here.

MARA: That's OK. It's practice. Run scrimmage, get the plays down pat, then we shove the patients under there and let fly. We don't ever check the face.

MORT: Unless there's a beard. We don't want a beard in the muck.

MARA: What do you think? Rapid Shave? Drano? Easy-Off?

MORT: Wait. He's not real. He's imaginary.

MARA: Then we better work fast. You take the steak knife, I've got the juicer.

MORT: Roger! *(They begin burlesque surgery: broad, gross pantomime.)*

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MARA: Take that out, I saw it move.

MORT: Arthritis. Out with his bones.

MARA: How about the kidneys?

MORT: Feel OK. Oh-oh, bed's wet. Can't have that.

MARA: You did a no-no.

MORT: Give 'em the heave.

MARA: Squeeze that.

MORT: Not very fresh.

MARA: Mold.

MORT: Out.

MARA: Let's do a brain test. What are the three justifications for existence? Wrong. Take out the brain.

MORT: What about the liver?

MARA: We had liver last night.

MORT: Well, it's cheap.

MARA: Three dollars a pound?

MORT: For that we could buy sweetbreads.

MARA: He didn't complain of sweetbreads.

MORT: Out.

MARA: Better wash all this off.

MORT: Wait. I got a bite.

MARA: All we can do is pray.

MORT: Pull out the plug.

MARA: Locomotor ataxia.

MORT: Dynamite up the kazoo! Take cover! *(Catastrophic explosion)*

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MARA: Got him.

MORT: Is he OK?

MARA: He's dead.

MORT: But he's imaginary.

MARA: He is now. *(Blurred focus)*

MORT: Hey, what am I doing? I'm not the doctor, I'm supposed to see the doctor...

MARA: No, come on, you better be the doctor ...

MORT: I can't speak Latin. I missed the test. Is there a Band-Aid in the house?

MARA: We're running out of gas ... *(He transforms into a concrete character: a fatigued fifty-year-old physician, speaking to us directly.)*

MORT: I have a patient. Forty years old. Female. White. The most radiant, life-loving woman I know.

MARA: She's a patient. She's dying.

MORT: She has leukemia. She's dying. I do bone-marrow biopsies. Which are very painful. She's had remission twice. Then it goes on.

MARA: She's losing her looks.

MORT: She tries to joke.

MARA: Symptoms?

MORT: Symptoms? I feel a cold sweat. Shaking. I try to laugh.

MARA: Prognosis?

MORT: Six months.

MARA: Side effects?

MORT: Side effects?

MARA: Any side effects?

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MORT: You die.

MARA: Who dies?

MORT: The patient dies.

MARA: Who's the patient?

MORT: The patient pays the piper.

MARA: Then who pays the doctor?

MORT: Whoever's dying.

MARA: Everyone's dying. *(Pause. Incredulous)*

MORT: No... *(Stark awake, they kneel clumsily side by side on the bed, hands in prayer.)* I'm the patient now.

MARA: I'm the patient too. *(They mumble in shambling unison.)*

BOTH: Yea though I walk through the valley of the shadow of Yea though I walk through the valley of

Yea though

Valley of

Sha

Va

I fear no evil!

No evil.

Yea though I fear no

Yea though I fear no

Yea though I walk through the valley of

The Shadow of

(Their lips form a word, soundlessly. Fade.)

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